

Aftermath in Indochina

The last United States citizens departed from Indochina in 1975, and Vietnam was reunified. The American war was over, but there was little respite: for the Indochinese, conflict merely moved into another stage, referred to as the Third Indochina War.

◀◀ BEFORE

Long-disputed boundaries and hostility toward migrants made it easy for conflicts to emerge.

DIFFERENCES ASIDE

The Indochinese powers had buried their difficulties during the **First Indochina War** against the French, and both Cambodia and Laos had been attacked by North Vietnam's enemies during the Second Indochina War. North Vietnam had built their main supply route, the **Ho Chi Minh Trail**, through Laos, and Cambodia was sucked into the war by Nixon's **Cambodian incursion**. However, the three nations, along with their Chinese neighbor in the north, had an ancient history of **border and ethnic disputes** dating from long before French colonization.

The Second Indochina War came to an end in 1975, with communist governments in power in all three Indochina countries, but the scars of the conflict were deep. Whatever levels of cooperation under the fraternal banner of communism might have existed during the war quickly fell apart, as historical animosities prevailed. The following decades were a dark and violent time in Vietnam, Cambodia, and Laos.

Centuries of antipathy between Cambodia and Vietnam, somewhat covered over during the Indochina Wars, resurfaced after the triumph of communist regimes in both countries in 1975.

Ancient grudge

Tensions soon erupted into armed conflict. Ethnic and border issues, as well as conflicting claims over islands, resulted in military skirmishes that escalated to major engagements. Following months of attacks on Vietnamese villages, in September 1977 Democratic Kampuchea (the new Khmer Rouge regime in Cambodia) sent six divisions into Vietnam's Tay Ninh province. The new Socialist Republic of Vietnam (SRV) was quick to respond; it amassed eight divisions, invaded Kampuchea, and by January 1978 its troops came within 24 miles (39 km) of Phnom Penh before withdrawing.

More border conflicts resulted in another Vietnamese incursion in June and a full-scale invasion was launched on December 25, 1978. Employing 13 divisions, 150,000 soldiers, and abundant artillery and airpower, Vietnam wiped out half of the Kampuchean Revolutionary Army in only two weeks. Khmer Rouge political leaders fled to the western regions of the country.

On January 7, 1979, Vietnam installed a puppet government, the People's Republic of Kampuchea, headed by Heng Samrin and other former Khmer Rouge defectors.